

A changing world

The family unit is ever changing and has undergone some major shifts in the past few decades. Although times have changed, your role as a parent is the same as ever: to give your child consistent love, loyalty, and care.

Families today

There are many varieties of family life. Although studies report on the problems of modern childhood, children tend to be familiar with and tolerant of different cultures, and living and working practices.

Mature moms The number of births to women in the US between 35–39 has risen 52 percent since 1990; the birth rate in women 40–44 has risen 65 percent since 1990 and is at an all-time high. Benefits are that older women are more likely to be settled, financially stable, and mature.

Single parenting Approximately 23 percent of US children under the age of 18 live in a single-parent family, which is the highest rate in the world. There's no doubt that children in single-parent families can be disadvantaged, but it's thought that much of this is due to financial constraints and that those who have adequate socioeconomic resources do well.

Blended, or mixed, families This is when families combine, forming a blend of stepchildren, adopted or foster children, and biologic children. It is the fastest-growing household type.

Modern dads

Dads today are more involved in family life. Some 93 percent attend the birth (compared to 5 percent in 1965), and over 70 percent take time off after the birth. In the 1970s, dads of children under five devoted less than 15 minutes a day to child-related activities, compared to over two hours by the 1990s. Research shows that children whose dads spend considerable time with them do well educationally and at work.

Child care

Studies show that good care outside the family has a positive impact on social skills, intellect, and language. A good grandparent relationship provides stability and family values, and is thought to improve cognitive development. Grandparents care for about 30 percent of US babies.